# 2
# BRICS and the sub-imperial location

Patrick Bond

The notion of 'sub-imperialist' states that accompany and extend imperialism was originally invoked by Ruy Mauro Marini (1965) to describe the Brazilian dictatorship's role in the western hemisphere. The sub-imperialist label was then repeatedly applied during the 1970s when the Nixon Doctrine allowed Washington to outsource geopolitical policing responsibilities and accumulation opportunities to favoured regional allies, mostly pro-corporate authoritarian regimes. The idea may be on the verge of being revived, for the rise of the Brazil-Russia-India-China-South Africa (BRICS) bloc represents a potentially important force that mostly appears sub-imperialist insofar as it contributes to global neoliberal regime maintenance. Although some believe BRICS will have sufficient autonomy to become actively 'anti-imperialist' (Desai 2013; Escobar 2013; Keet 2013; Martin 2013; Shubin 2013; Third World Network 2013), at the level of global governance this bloc has tended to reinforce, not challenge, prevailing power relations. There are interesting exceptions: cases such as generic medicines (so vital to the health of tens of millions of HIV+ people) and geopolitics, as in 2013 when Syria was threatened with bombing by Washington and in 2014 when Russia invaded Crimea after losing crucial influence in Ukraine. Like other more isolated states in prior epochs of service to imperialism, the BRICS accumulation trajectory, global geopolitical-economic-environmental strategy, hegemony over hinterlands and internal dynamics of class formation collectively suggest a pattern deserving the phrase sub-imperialist.

The debate about whether imperialism *requires* sub-imperial allies has waxed and waned for decades. In the Comintern era, the phrase 'minor partner of imperialism' described the great powers' deputies. Since the 1970s, the label sub-